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YOUTHSPEAK

# THE AUDACITY OF YOUTH

**Today, India's youth are more informed than ever before. Their hopes for the future include self-reliance, a more positive media culture, less crime, more inclusivity and free speech**

By SONALI ACHARJEE



*Illustration by* TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

With an average age of 29, India is currently home to a fifth of the world's youth population. The United Nations Population Fund predicts that this 'youth bulge'—often referred to as India's demographic dividend—will last till about 2025, with India continuing to have one of the youngest populations in the world till 2030.

In the coming decade, more young people than ever before will join the country's work force. Young people today are highly informed, aware of both domestic and international issues and increasingly technologically savvy. They are also highly mobile: according to a recent study by the Institute for Governance, Policies and Politics in Delhi, around 86 per cent of those aged 18-25 access the internet and social media through mobile phones. This constant exposure to different views, trends and news has resulted in adolescents and young adults with high aspirations for themselves and India.

Whether it is pollution, the continuing lack of gender equality or the shortage of jobs, young people today are clear-sighted about the problems facing our country and aren't afraid to name them. Take 16-year-old Shyla Upadhyay, a student at Delhi's Vasant Valley School,